

Historical Background

Polity | Quick Revision Notes for fast recall

Theme: Evolution of constitutional development	Use: Prelims + Mains	Focus: Acts, commissions, transfer of power
--	----------------------	---

1. Big Picture

- Modern Indian constitutional development began under British colonial rule, where power gradually shifted from the East India Company to the British Crown.
- The long trail of reforms was shaped by administrative needs, pressure from Indians, and later the demand for swaraj and responsible government.
- UPSC usually tests this area as a sequence: Act -> feature -> significance -> how it led to the next stage.

2. Key Milestones

Year	Milestone
1773	Regulating Act: first major step to regulate Company rule; Governor-General of Bengal created.
1784	Pitt's India Act: introduced dual control - Company and British government.
1858	Government of India Act: Company rule ended; Crown rule began.
1861	Indian Councils Act: legislative councils expanded; portfolio system introduced.
1892	Councils Act: indirect election element and wider discussion in councils.
1909	Morley-Minto Reforms: separate electorates for Muslims.
1919	Montagu-Chelmsford Reforms: dyarchy in provinces; diarchy often appears as a trap.
1935	Government of India Act: federation idea, provincial autonomy, and a strong centre.

3. Road to the Constitution

- 1916-1929: Congress and nationalist leaders increasingly demanded a constitution made by Indians themselves.
- 1934: M. N. Roy and others pushed the idea of a Constituent Assembly as a concrete political demand.
- 1940: The British, through the August Offer, acknowledged the principle that Indians should frame their own constitution.
- 1946: The Cabinet Mission Plan provided the mechanism for electing the Constituent Assembly.

4. Why 1935 Matters

- The Government of India Act, 1935 was the most important pre-Independence constitutional law.
- It offered provincial autonomy, proposed a federal structure, and influenced many later constitutional features.
- Several constitutional ideas in 1950 were refined versions of what had already been tried under this Act.

5. Why the Background Matters

- It shows that the Constitution was not written in a vacuum; it grew out of colonial governance and nationalist resistance.
- Understanding the background helps in questions on borrowed features, committee evolution, and the difference between reform and self-government.
- For mains answers, this topic helps build a short introduction on how India moved from Company rule to constitutional democracy.

6. Prelims Traps

- Do not mix up the Regulating Act, 1773 with the Pitt's India Act, 1784.
- The 1909 Act is remembered for separate electorates, while the 1919 Act is remembered for dyarchy.
- The 1935 Act is the biggest predecessor to the Constitution, not the 1942 Cripps Mission.
- The Cripps Mission failed, but it is still important as a step toward later transfer-of-power negotiations.

One-line revision: Indian constitutional history moved from Company control to Crown rule, then through reform acts, nationalist demands, the 1935 Act, and the Cabinet Mission plan to the Constituent Assembly and the Constitution of 1950.

7. Fast Recall

1773	Regulating Act
1858	Crown rule begins
1909	Separate electorates
1919	Dyarchy
1935	Provincial autonomy + federal idea
1946	Cabinet Mission and Constituent Assembly